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NOTES FROM A TRIUMPH
Clockwise from above, ISRO chairman S. Somanath (fourth from left) and other scientists celebrate the landing of Chandrayaan-3 at mission control, Bengaluru; Portion of Chandrayaan-3's landing site; Prime Minister Narendra Modi keeps track of India's achievement from Johannesburg;

A HISTORIC FIRST

Chandrayaan-3 soft-lands near the lunar South Pole after a 41-day voyage

India is the 4th country to land a spacecraft on the moon after the former USSR, US and China

It is also the first country to land a spacecraft near the moon's South Pole

The lander's instruments will study the moon's thermal and seismic properties; rover Pragyaan will analyse the lunar soil

Chandrayaan-1, launched on Oct. 22, 2008, was lost before its two-year tenure, but provided conclusive evidence of water and ice on the moon

Chandrayaan-2, launched on July 22, 2019, failed to soft-land but provided rich data and learnings. Its orbiter is still serving as a communications backup for Chandrayaan-3

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Beyond the rejoicing and warm glow of achievement, there is the larger picture. Chandrayaan-3's gloriously pitch-perfect soft-landing on the moon on August 23, 2023, signifies more than the fact of its double triumph: India is now the fourth country to land a spacecraft on the moon, and the first to land on the lunar South Pole. The feat will benefit not only India, it will also enable the world to have a better understanding of this area on the dark side of the moon. The craters permanently in the shadow here are expected to hold frozen water, and the solar-powered Pragyaan rover will roam the lunar surface for 14 days, gathering images and data. Its findings will now be analysed the world over.

What is more, Chandrayaan's success marks our maturing as a space power—a major turning point in the country's space odyssey that began when a slender SLV-3 rocket, launched on July 18, 1980, from the nascent Satish Dhawan Space Centre at Sriharikota, lobbed a Rohini satellite into orbit, making India the sixth member of an exclusive club of spacefaring nations. This historic landing, using a much heavier LVM3-M4 launcher from Sriharikota, also underlines the stupendous frugality of India's space engineering—mission after mission, it has pushed boundaries in space exploration at a fraction of the spending by the leading space powers. In fact, the prospect of prohibitive costs is hardly a deterrent for the space scientists of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). "How and in what way we have cut costs will remain a secret in order to stay ahead of other spacefaring nations," asserts a beaming ISRO chairman, S. Somanath. Chandrayaan-3 is estimated to have cost Rs 615 crore.

The moment of the Vikram